Total Disconnect: Communication Patterns between Child Protection and School Systems

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Minn-LInK Minnesota-Linking Information for Kids

http://z.umn.edu/s1q

Integrated Data



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Objective

This study relied on case record review and analysis of integrated administrative child protection services (CPS) and educational data to answer the following:

- What contact occurs between CPS and school systems?
- Does communication differ depending on child/case characteristics?
- Does communication make a difference for academic outcomes?

Methods

A case review of child protection records was completed for 156 school-age children. Through Minn-LInK, administrative child welfare and education records were linked to case record review data. Comparison groups were created to examine differences in communication between child protection and school systems during CPS assessment/investigation by the following case characteristics:

- **Family Investigation (FI)** vs. **Family Assessment (FA)**
- **Out-of-Home Placement (OHP)** vs. **In-Home Placement (IHP)**
- **Academic Issues (AI)** vs. **No Academic Issues (NAI)**

Chi-square analyses were used to examine differences in communication patterns dependent upon case characteristics (i.e., FI, FA, OHP, IHP, AI, NAI). Student proficiency on MCA-II math and reading tests as well as attendance data were examined based on extent of communication (received/not received) using chi-square analyses.

Results

- Overall, 81% of cases received contact between CPS and school.
  - Contact was largely initiated by CPS social workers via face-to-face or phone call.
  - Majority of contact was with the child or other personnel (e.g., foster parents, court personnel, therapist), not teachers or school personnel.
  - Reasons for contact varied, but contact was generally made for truancy/attendance or school well-being issues (see Figure 1)
- There were significant differences in communication patterns between students with academic issues and those without (See Table 2)
- While proficiency on MCA-II math and reading tests did not differ between students who received contact and those who did not, scores were consistently lower for both groups compared to the general student population. Attendance mean was significantly lower for students who did not receive contact (.80) compared to students who received contact (.84).

Figure 1. Patterns of Communication Between CPS and Schools

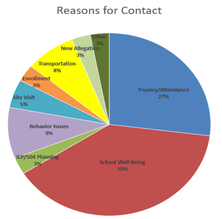


Table 2: Communication Patterns By Case Characteristics

	FI	FA	OHP	IHP	Academic Issues	None
Cases Receiving CPS-School Contact	77%	76%	73%	77%	**90%**	**73%**
Mean Contacts Per Child	3.23	2.72	3.50	4.16	**9.52**	**2.87**
Contacts Initiated by CPS	76%	73%	77%	73%	**66%**	**80%**
Contact Received per Group						
School Personnel	**55%**	**47%**	**38%**	**48%**	**56%**	**40%**
Child or Other Personnel	**45%**	**53%**	**62%**	**52%**	**44%**	**60%**
Face-to-Face Contact per Group						
School Personnel	13%	16%	22%	22%	**37%**	**15%**
Child or *Other Personnel	87%	84%	78%	78%	**63%**	**85%**
Contacts by Type						
Face-to-Face	45%	49%	47%	42%	**35%**	**49%**
Phone Call	32%	30%	**35%**	**27%**	28%	29%
Reports & Documents	**11%**	**6%**	**3%**	**13%**	12%	10%
Email	0%	0%	0%	1%	2%	0%
Letter	0%	0%	0%	3%	**5%**	**0%**
Attempted Face-to-Face	1%	0%	0%	3%	5%	1%
Attempted Call	10%	13%	15%	10%	13%	10%
Reason for Contact						
Truancy/Attendance	**21%**	**8%**	**13%**	**28%**	**63%**	**9%**
School Well-Being	**39%**	**53%**	**42%**	**35%**	**15%**	**46%**
IEP/504 Planning	1%	5%	3%	3%	2%	4%
Behavior Issues	11%	12%	8%	11%	**4%**	**13%**
Site Visit	**36%**	**6%**	**3%**	**11%**	5%	11%
Enrollment	0%	5%	0%	5%	6%	3%
Transportation	8%	6%	**23%**	**3%**	4%	8%
New Allegation	7%	4%	7%	4%	2%	6%
Other	0%	1%	1%	0%	0%	0%

(Click Figures to Enlarge)

Conclusions

- Overall cross-system communication patterns reflect a disconnect between systems. Not all CPS cases identified or referred because of educational neglect received school contact. There appeared to be differences in cross-system communication depending on case characteristics. Most CPS contact was made with the child or others, instead of school personnel; this reflects a missed opportunity for collaborative efforts between systems to ensure educational success and stability for the student.
- Although proficiency scores did not differ between students who received contact and those who did not, students with CPS involvement generally had lower levels of proficiency compared to the general student population.

References

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Table 1. Demographic Characteristics

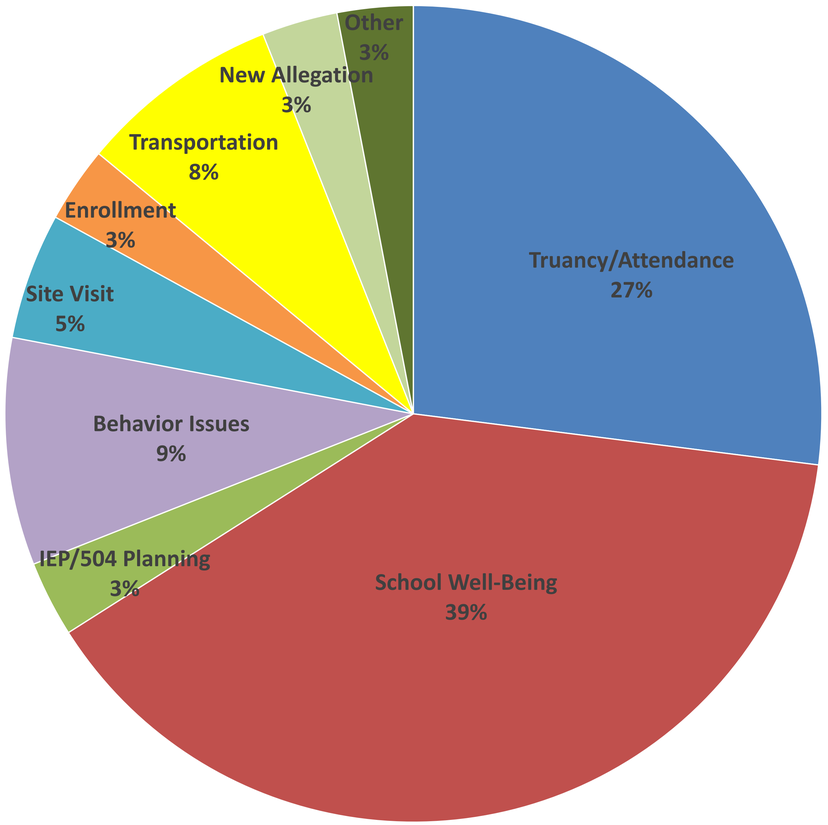
Characteristic	Overall (n=156)
Gender	
Male	49%
Female	51%
Mean Age	11.56
Ethnicity	
American Indian/Alaskan Native	1%
Asian	7%
Hispanic	10%
Black or African American	45%
White or Caucasian	37%
Pacific Islander	1%
Limited English Proficiency	8%
Free and Reduced Lunch Eligibility	91%
OHP Involvement	27%
Educational Indicators	
Special Education Involvement	38%
Academic Issues	20%
School Mobility	58%
*Attendance	.83
[a] MCA-II Math Proficient	10%
[a] MCA-II Reading Proficient	25%

Note. *An attendance proportion equal to or above .90 indicates satisfactory attendance (Balfanz & Byrnes, 2012). [a]MCA-II proficiency scores are only available for students between 3rd and 8th grade, 10th and 11th. As such, scores are not available for all students in the sample. Proficiency scores are reported to reflect the proportion of students meeting math and/or reading proficiency during CPS involvement.

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Figure 1. Patterns of Communication Between CPS and Schools

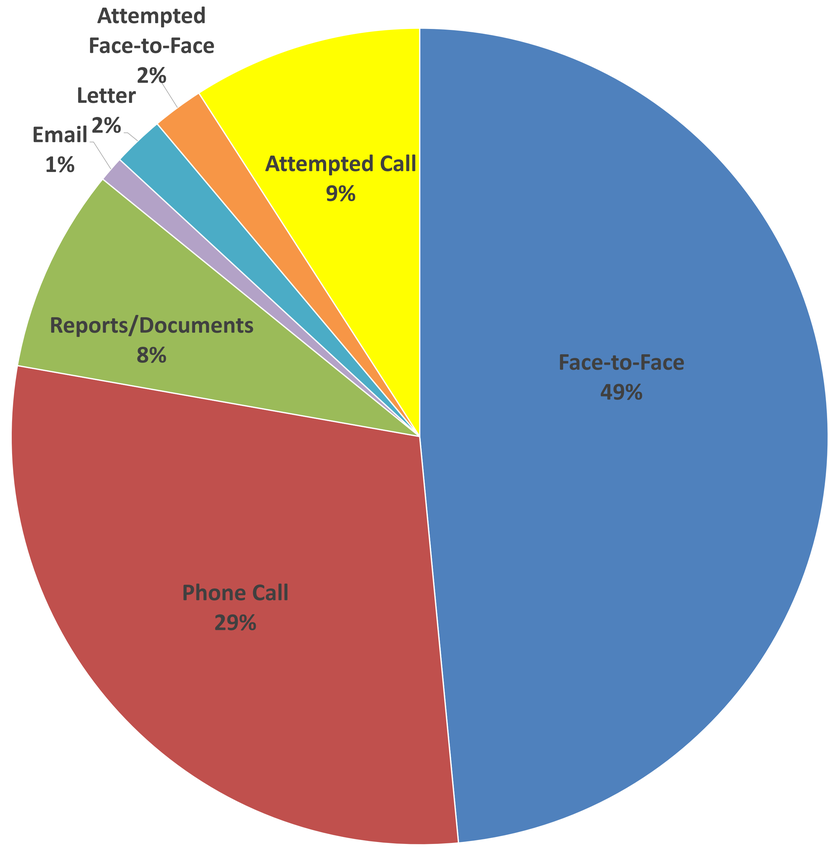
Reasons for Contact



Communication Patterns

	Proportion
Cases Receiving CPS-School Contact	81%
Contacts Initiated by CPS	69%
Contact Received per Group	
School Personnel	37%
Child or Other Personnel	63%
Face-to-Face Contact per Group	
School Personnel	16%
Child or Other Personnel	84%

Type of Contact



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Other	0%	1%	1%	0%	0%	0%

Note: **Boldface** indicates statistical significance at the $p<.05$ level between the following paired groups: FI/FA, OHP/IHP, and Academic Issues/None. *Other Personnel includes individuals such as parent, foster parent or caregiver, court personnel, court attorney, therapist or mental health provider.

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